

The SOS flow — animation & state machine brief

Round one gave us the panda, the hero pose, the breathing loop and the four feelings. This round puts the character into the panic path itself: the screens someone sees after they tap SOS. Two briefs here — first **what to animate**, then **how the Rive file should be wired** so the app can drive it.

PROJECT	TOOL	SCREEN	GROUND
Sidekick — anxiety & panic support	Rive, one .riv file	Mobile, 390 × 844pt	Cream #F6F1E2 · panic screens #1B2418

The background values have shifted a touch since round one — these are the current ones. The character still has to read on both.

1 Animation for the SOS flow

The SOS path is dark, one thing per screen, no navigation. The panda is on every screen of it except one, and it has one job throughout: **model recovery**. It gets startled, it visibly comes down, and then it stays down — calm, steady, breathing — while the person catches up with it.

All text, buttons and screen chrome are the app's job. Yours is the panda and the anxiety monster.

The entry — three beats

The moment SOS is tapped, before any text appears:

0.0s

Startle

Paws up, sharp. Held for 0.5s.
Mirrors the person — something is wrong.

0.5s

Coming down

Paws lower, shoulders drop. A 1.5s ease-out — the recovery made visible.

2.0s

Settled

Seated, still, breathing slowly. The first mantra fades in over this.

Two seconds total. The startle must be short — it plays once, ever, per session.

The startle never repeats. If someone leaves and taps SOS again in the same session, the app opens the flow directly at the settled pose. Being startled twice reads as the panda panicking too, which is the opposite of its job. This is the single biggest reason the file needs a proper state machine — see brief 2.

Settled — the mantra screens

- The seated pose from beat three, held as a gentle idle loop. Slow breathing, the occasional blink. Nothing busier than that.
- The app fades mantra lines in over it, about one every 6 seconds. **No talking animation** — the panda simply sits and breathes while the lines change.
- This idle needs to hold up for a couple of minutes without feeling like a loop.

Guided breathing — the pacer

This reuses the round-one breathing loop, and the same rules apply:

- The panda's body *is* the pacer. Belly expands on the in-breath, contracts on the out-breath. There is no ring and no counter graphic — the character is the only timing cue, so subtle is the one thing it can't be.
- Build the in-breath and the out-breath as **separate, independently stretchable timelines**. The app drives the pace: roughly 4 in · 6 out during SOS, and the meditation feature reuses the same motion at 4 in · 4 hold · 6 out. So there is also a brief **hold** moment — a beat of stillness at full breath the app can stretch or skip.
- Clear, distinct beats at the turn of each breath — haptics land on them.

- The anxiety monster sits beside the panda and **shrinks as the breathing goes on**. The app will drive its size with a number, so build the shrink as a scale the file can be told, not a baked timeline.

Grounding

- The one separate pose in the exercise: seated, paws flat on the floor, very still, breathing slowly.
- It needs a way in **from the breathing loop without a visible cut** — the panda finishes its out-breath and comes to rest, rather than jumping.

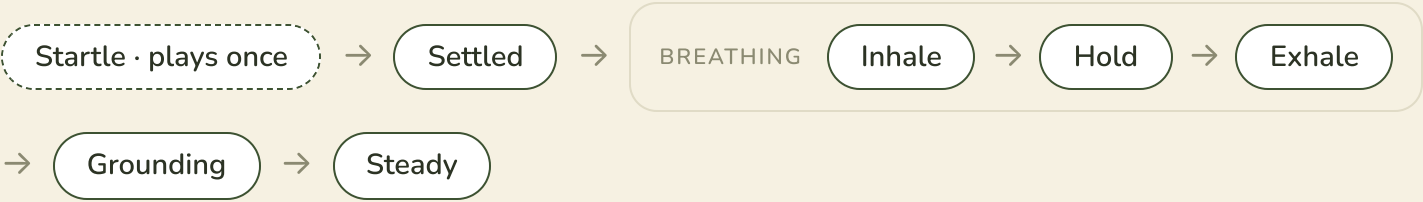
The check-in and the two exits

- **“Feeling steadier?”** — the settled idle works here as-is. Neutral, asking, no cartoon faces. Either answer is fine, and the pose shouldn't lean on one.
- **Still escalating → crisis resources**. The panda is *absent* on this screen. No mascot, no warmth — real phone numbers only. Nothing for you to draw; named here so its absence is a decision you know about, not a gap.
- **Steadier → the recap**. “That passed.” The panda stands steady in the **same pose as the Home idle**. The screen returns to light. Coming out of the dark path and finding the panda exactly as it is at home is the point — please reuse the pose rather than making a near-match.

2 State machine management

How the app and the file talk: the app loads the .riv, binds its view model, and then drives it by setting named booleans and numbers and firing named triggers. The state machine inside the file decides what actually plays. The app never scrubs timelines — so every behaviour above has to exist as a state, and every switch as a transition.

The states



Entry goes to Startle the first time, straight to Settled on re-entry.
Exhale loops back to Inhale until the app says otherwise. Steady is reachable from Settled and Grounding both.

STATE	WHAT PLAYS	KIND
Startle	The three beats: paws up → come down → arrive seated	One-shot, ~2s, never re-entered
Settled	Seated idle: slow breath, occasional blink	Loop
Inhale	Belly expands, monster beside	Timeline, stretchable
Hold	Still at full breath	Timeline, stretchable, skippable
Exhale	Belly contracts	Timeline, stretchable
Grounding	Seated, paws flat, very still	Loop
Steady	The Home idle pose, standing, calm	Loop

The inputs

Exposed on the file's view model, so the app can reach them. Proposed names — if any need to change, tell me before the file ships, because these names go into the app's code and changing one afterwards breaks the app.

NAME	TYPE	WHAT IT DOES
skipStartle	boolean	Set before play. True → entry goes straight to Settled. This is the re-entry rule from brief 1.
breathe	boolean	True → move from Settled into the breathing loop. False → breathe out, come to rest in Settled.
ground	trigger	Breathing → Grounding, after the current breath completes.
steady	trigger	Anywhere → Steady, for the recap.
monster	number 0–100	Anxiety monster size. 100 = full, 0 = gone. The app eases it down as breathing progresses.

Plain English names, please, and a written list. In kuzu.riv the ear triggers came out as **lKuḷak** and **rKuḷak**, which works but needs a translator. For this file: English names, and a short list shipped alongside it of every artboard name, state machine name, and input — spelled exactly. The app selects all of these by name.

Transition rules

FROM	TO	WHEN	RULE
Entry	Startle / Settled	on load	Settled if skipStartle is true
Startle	Settled	automatically	One-way. No path ever leads back in.
Settled	Inhale	breathe = true	Start at the top of an in-breath, from rest
Exhale	Inhale / Settled	end of exhale	Loops while breathe stays true
Breathing	Grounding	ground	Finish the current exhale first — no visible cut
Any	Steady	steady	A short, calm blend. Never a pop.

The rule underneath all of these: **a transition only fires on a natural boundary** — the end of an out-breath, the end of a beat. The person is copying the panda's body with their own; a mid-breath jump is genuinely disorienting here, not just untidy.

Three technical constraints from the app

1. **Every state's first frame must work as a still.** When a phone has “reduce motion” switched on, the app freezes the animation on its first frame instead of playing it. Whatever frame each state opens on is the poster image those users live with.
2. **Loops must be seamless and long-lived.** The settled idle and the breathing loop each run for several minutes across screen changes. No drift, no visible seam, no fidget that becomes a tic on the tenth repeat.
3. **No Rive listeners needed.** The app does its own tap handling and pokes the inputs from outside. Don't wire pointer events inside the file.

✓ How I'll check the file

The review, so nothing here is a surprise:

- ☐ Play twice: first run shows the startle, a run with `skipStartle` opens settled — no flash of paws.
- ☐ Freeze the first frame of every state: each one reads as a decent still.
- ☐ Fire `ground` mid-inhale: the panda finishes the breath, then comes to rest. No cut.
- ☐ Let the breathing loop run five minutes at SOS pace and again at meditation pace: no seam, no drift.
- ☐ Slide `monster` from 100 to 0: the monster shrinks smoothly and is gone at zero.
- ☐ Every artboard, state machine and input name matches the shipped list, letter for letter.
- ☐ Both grounds: the character reads on cream #F6F1E2 and on #1B2418.

Questions before you start are cheaper than questions after — especially on the input names and the stretchable breathing timelines. Same review shape as round

one: send work-in-progress across before we meet, and tell me whether Wednesday or Friday suits.